Shachi Devi

Шачи-деви (Шачимата) · @shachi

Shachi Devi is the mother of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, the Lord's eternal mother. In Vraja she is called Yashoda, the queen of Vraja; in Navadvipa she became the one at whose breast the Lord fell asleep, whom He obeyed and before whom He was wilful, like any child. Krishnadasa Kaviraja says it in a single line:

“Thus I have briefly told of the descent of Lord Chaitanya. As Krishna became the son of Yashoda, so Sri Chaitanya became the son of Shachidevi.” (CC, Adi 14.3)

The fullest account of her life is given by Vrindavana Dasa Thakura in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”; much is added by the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, by the Sanskrit life written by Murari Gupta and by Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala”.

Daughter of Nilambara Chakravarti

Shachi was the daughter of Nilambara Chakravarti, a learned brahmana well versed in the science of the stars. Her husband was Jagannatha Mishra, who had come from Shrihatta, settled in Navadvipa and was known by the title Purandara. Krishnadasa Kaviraja introduces her thus:

“His wife, Srimati Shachidevi, was a chaste woman, wholly devoted to her husband. Her father was Nilambara Chakravarti.” (CC, Adi 13.60)

Shachi had a sister, Sarvajaya, the wife of Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna, who was thus the Lord's uncle on His mother's side. Even before Mahaprabhu's appearance Chandrashekhara and his wife were constant visitors at Mishra's house and helped to run the household.[1] Other dear ones lived close by. Ratnavati, the mother of Gadadhara Pandita, looked upon Shachi as an elder sister, and the two were hardly ever apart. Malini, Srivasa's wife, was Shachi's inseparable friend: they were always happy together, and when the time of the birth came, Malini tended Shachi like the most devoted of nurses.

Shachi did not come into the world by chance. Before appearing Himself, the Lord sends down to the earth those whom He will honour as His parents and elders, and Krishnadasa Kaviraja names her among them twice:

“Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri, Srimati Shachimata and Jagannatha Mishra appeared together with Advaita Acharya.” (CC, Adi 3.94)

“Sri Shachidevi and Jagannatha Mishra, Sri Madhavendra Puri, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Srivasa Pandita, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Adi 13.54–55)

The first years of the marriage were years of loss. One after another eight daughters were born to Shachi, and not one of them lived:

“Before the appearance of Sri Chaitanya eight daughters were born to Shachi and Jagannatha Mishra. But they died immediately after birth.” (CC, Adi 13.72)

Jagannatha began to worship Vishnu, praying for a son, and Vishvarupa was born — a manifestation of Baladeva, the Sankarshana of the spiritual world (CC, Adi 13.73–74). The boy was beautiful, detached from worldly things from early childhood, and while still a child grasped the meaning of the scriptures; His parents could not look at Him enough (CB, Adi 2.140–142). So in the house where the Lord was to appear, His elder brother came to live before Him.

Mother of the Universe

Vrindavana Dasa, beginning his account of the Lord's appearance, names her chief quality:

“His faithful wife, Srimati Shachi Devi, was the embodiment of pure devotion to the Supreme Lord. She is the Mother of the universe.” (CB, Adi 2.139)

Jagannatha Mishra and Shachi Devi are eternal companions of Krishna, never bound by this world. Their hearts and bodies are of pure goodness, shuddha-sattva, which is called “vasudeva”: in it alone does the Lord appear. Vrindavana Dasa says that Shachi beheld what is hidden from others because “the Vedas call her the embodiment of service to Lord Vishnu” (CB, Adi 12.230), and he calls her tenderly “Ai”, “mother”: if anyone merely utters this word, it frees him from all suffering (CB, Madhya 13.374).

Who she is in the eternal lila is told by Krishnadasa Kaviraja and by Kavi Karnapura:

“The king of Vraja, Nanda Maharaja, has now become the father of Sri Chaitanya, and Yashoda, the queen of Vraja, has become His mother, Sri Shachidevi.” (CC, Adi 17.294)

“Yashoda and the king of Vraja, Nanda, who once in Vrindavana were mines of the rasa of love, became Shachi and Jagannatha Purandara — of this there is no doubt. Into them also entered the divine Aditi and Kashyapa, Sri Kaushalya and Dasharatha, and Sri Prishni and her husband.” (GGD 37–38)

Thus all who in earlier descents had been mothers of God were united in Shachi;[2] yet she herself is Yashoda, the very essence of motherly love. In this lies the secret of her life. The Mother of the universe fears for her Son, scolds Him, runs after Him with a stick, weeps for Him and does not remember His majesty — not because maya has power over her: it is yogamaya, the Lord's internal potency, that veils His majesty so that nothing may constrain pure parental love, vatsalya. Only His eternal associate can treat the Lord as a son; the Lord Himself, sitting in her arms, is never under the sway of maya, and neither is His mother.

The Lord in Shachi's Womb

In the month of Magha of the year 1406 of the Shaka era (January 1485) the Lord Himself entered the bodies of Shachi and Jagannatha (CC, Adi 13.80). The couple were the first to notice the change:

“One day Jagannatha Mishra said to Shachidevi: ‘I have witnessed an astonishing wonder! Your form radiates such effulgence, as if the goddess Lakshmi herself had come to live in our house. Wherever I go, people show me respect and of their own accord give me wealth, clothes, rice and much else.’ Shachidevi replied: ‘I too see in the sky the forms of divine beings offering prayers.’” (CC, Adi 13.81–83)

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” relates that when the Lord entered Shachi and Jagannatha, the couple heard Ananta's cries of “Victory! Victory!” and thought they were dreaming. Brahma and the other gods, remaining unseen, came every day to glorify Him who, though the shelter of countless universes, had entered Shachi's womb, and they bowed to her house (CB, Adi 2.144–154, 193–195). Murari Gupta gives their hymn, addressed to her herself: “We bow to you who ever bear Him in your womb! You are Aditi, the mother of Hari… You bear in your womb Him who will spread the holiest of sacrifices — kirtana” (“Kadacha” 1.5.8–10).

Lochana Dasa adds that day by day Shachi's body shone more brightly and people wondered: “We do not know who has come to Shachi's house.” In the sixth month Advaita Acharya came to them. Shachi brought Him water to wash His feet, and He, with tears in His eyes, walked around her and bowed down to her; Shachi started at such a breach of custom, the couple asked in bewilderment what it meant, and Jagannatha received only the answer: “Later you will know everything.” The gods came too; Shachi felt their presence and rejoiced, though at times she was frightened to see their host. And her heart in those days became like this:

“Shachi's heart was filled with compassion for all beings: she is kind [to all] as to herself, not distinguishing her own from others.” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 1, v. 46)

The Lord remained in her womb until the full moon of the month of Phalguna (CB, Adi 2.195). On the full moon of Phalguna in the year 1407 of the Shaka era (February 1486), at dusk, during an eclipse of the moon, when all over Nadia people were singing the holy names on the pretext of the eclipse, Gaurachandra rose from the ocean of her womb like a golden moon. Thus in Mayapur the Lord accepted Jagannatha and Shachi as His father and mother. The gods, in the guise of ordinary people, came to Shachi's house and sang the names of Hari aloud (CB, Adi 2.226–233). In Lochana Dasa, Shachi, beside herself with happiness, beckons to her husband:

“‘Our life has borne fruit — look at our son's face!’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 1, v. 55)

Seeing the Child's face, both forgot themselves for joy. Nilambara Chakravarti hurried to his son-in-law's house, cast his grandson's horoscope and, turning to Shachi, said that the Child would deliver both families for ever — the father's and the mother's; hearing her father's words, she was filled with joy (“Kadacha” 1.5.23–28). Gods and men hastened to Mishra's house, and the house became Vaikuntha. For eight days, as Bengali custom required, mother and child did not leave the birth chamber, and on the ninth a festival was held. Narahari sings of those days: happy Shachi holds her son on her lap, and crowds stream in to see Him.

Heavenly women also came to Shachi's house. Aditi, the mother of the gods, touched the Child's head with rice and durva grass and wished Him long life, and other goddesses were with her:

“Srimati Shachi Devi and the assembled guests were astonished to see the unearthly beauty of the goddesses, but did not dare to ask the strangers who they were and where they came from. The goddesses reverently took the dust from Shachi Devi's feet, and mother Shachi lost the power of speech for happiness.” (CB, Adi 3.37–38)

Malini did not come alone — with her was Chandrashekhara's wife, Shachi's sister:

“Malini, the wife of Srivasa Thakura, came with the wife of Chandrashekhara and many other women. With great joy they honoured the infant, offering Him vermilion, turmeric, oil, puffed rice, coconuts, bananas and other fruits.” (CC, Adi 13.110)

Soon, with Advaita's consent, His wife Sita Thakurani came from Shantipura in a covered palanquin with rich gifts. Entering Shachi's house, she was amazed: the Child was exactly like Krishna of Gokula, differing only in colour — and her heart melted with motherly love (CC, Adi 13.111–116). When mother and son first left the birth chamber, Shachi went with the women to the Ganga, worshipped the Ganga and the goddess Shashthi and, as custom required, gave the women puffed rice, bananas, oil, kumkum and betel, and they bowed down to her (CB, Adi 4.18–22). On that day Sita presented mother and child with clothes and ornaments, Shachi and Jagannatha honoured her, and she went home happy.

From then on Sita often came to Mayapur and taught Shachi how to bring up the Child; on His birthday the parents gave her the honour of being the first to offer Him new clothes. Sita and Shachi were of one heart — Nimai was their life, and day after day Sita helped to bring Him up. The Lord always treated Sita with the same reverence and love as His own mother, and therefore Vaishnavas honour Sita equally with Shachi, as a mother of the universe. Krishnadasa Kaviraja sums up those days:

“Thus Shachimata and Jagannatha Mishra obtained a son who was the husband of Lakshmi herself. All their desires were fulfilled, and from then on their house was always full of wealth and every kind of provision. And as they looked at their beloved child, Nimai, their happiness grew day by day.” (CC, Adi 13.119)

The Name “Nimai”

When the time came for the name-giving, the pandits led by Nilambara Chakravarti, friends and relatives gathered in Mishra's house. Opinions were divided: the pandits proposed one name, the venerable women another:

“[The women said:] ‘Since you have lost many daughters, let this child of yours bear the name Nimai.’” (CB, Adi 4.45)

The pandits reasoned that with the Child's birth the drought had given way to long-awaited rain and the whole world had found prosperity, and they named Him Vishvambhara, “He who sustains the universe”; His horoscope too pointed to this name. But the women's voice was not set aside:

“Let His second name be ‘Nimai’, as the venerable women advised.” (CB, Adi 4.50)

The nim is a bitter tree; witches and evil spirits, as people in Bengal believe, dare not approach it, and the bitterness of its leaves drives death away. So the mother who had lost eight daughters, and the women around her, protected the Child and wished Him long life.[3]

The Infant in His Mother's Arms

Shachi nursed the Child herself (CC, Adi 14.10). And already at four months He began His pranks: as soon as His mother went out, rice, grain and peas lay scattered all over the house and the pots of milk and yoghurt were broken; but the moment He sensed her coming, He climbed into His cot and began to cry. Anxious Shachi soothed Him by singing the names of Hari and only then noticed the havoc. No one could suspect the Child: they decided that an evil spirit had crept into the house, but the protective mantras had kept it from harming the Child, and in its vexation it had smashed the pots. The losses were considerable, but as soon as the parents looked at their son's face they forgot everything (CB, Adi 4.32–40). There were many wonders in the house, but the parents, fearing for the Child, told no one about them.

Once a snake crawled into the house, and the Child caught hold of it, lay down on its coils and smiled serenely. The grown-ups shouted, “Garuda! Garuda!” — “and the Lord's parents wept with fear” (CB, Adi 4.70). The snake — it was Ananta Himself — crawled away, while the Boy kept trying to catch it again; the women snatched Him up and wished Him long life.[4] When He crawled about everywhere, Shachi was often frightened, thinking that His reddish soles were bleeding. The couple were poor, but unearthly happiness never left their hearts (CB, Adi 4.82–83).

Once Jagannatha asked his son to bring him his book from the house. Nimai ran off — and a gentle tinkling of ankle-bells was heard, though He wore no bells. And when the couple went into the house, they saw everywhere the prints of small feet marked with the flag, the thunderbolt, the goad and the pennant. Their hair stood on end and tears poured from their eyes:

“Bowing down to these footprints, they said: ‘We are liberated! We shall not have to be born again.’” (CB, Adi 5.11)

Yet love would not let them admit that these were their son's footprints: Jagannatha decided that their household Deity, the Shalagrama Damodara, was walking about the house, asked “the mother of Vishvarupa” to prepare an offering for Him, and next morning they performed His bathing and puja, while Nimai smiled to Himself (CB, Adi 5.12–15). On another occasion Shachi, having taken her son to bed with her, saw that the house was full of celestial beings; she sent the Boy to call His father — and again the bells rang at His every step (CC, Adi 14.76–80; “Kadacha” 1.6.32–34). Lochana Dasa relates that one night the gods took the Child from her arms, seated Him on a jewelled throne and performed His abhisheka; Shachi called out in fear, “My son, my son!” — she had no fear for herself: her whole

life was in her son.

Lochana Dasa also preserves her lullaby:

“Moon, moon, moon up in the sky — who will pluck it and bring it to me? Wiping off its stain, I will paint a design on my Gora's forehead. Come, come, come! My golden little son Nimai is crying — He wants to sleep.” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 2)

At times she saw gods and goddesses come to her son and glorify Him, and she marvelled; at times He danced with the gods, crying “Radha-Govinda!”, and she fell senseless; at times she heard the bells on His bare little feet; at times fear seized her that some misfortune threatened Him — but the next moment, looking at His face, she forgot everything and kissed Him again and again.[5] When Nimai grew bigger and began to play in the courtyard, she carried Him in her arms and never took her eyes off Him, so that He would not break everything around.

Once a wandering brahmana came to the house. He cooked an offering for his Deity, and the Child ate it; the brahmana agreed to cook again, and so that the little rascal would not interfere once more, Shachi carried Him off to the neighbours (CB, Adi 5.46–52). Krishnadasa Kaviraja adds that the Child three times partook of the guest's offering and then, in private, granted him liberation (CC, Adi 14.37).

Nimai often cried — now for birds, now for the stars, now for the moon (“Pluck the moon and give it to Me!” — “Oh, You silly child! Who can catch the moon in the sky?” — CM, Adi-khanda, part 3, vv. 267–268) — and there was only one way to quiet Him: Shachi and the neighbouring women clapped their hands and sang the names of Hari. But once, on Ekadashi, the singing did not help. When they asked Him what He wanted, He answered: “If you want to save My life, go to Jagadisha and Hiranya: today they are fasting, but they have prepared an offering for Vishnu; when I eat it, I will stop crying.” Shachi threw up her hands and struck her forehead:

“‘What You ask is permitted neither by men nor by the Vedas.’” (CB, Adi 6.24)

The neighbours first gasped and then laughed. Jagadisha and Hiranya, learning of His wish, brought the whole offering themselves, for they understood that Krishna Himself was acting in this Child (CB, Adi 6.16–33).

Once Shachi gave her son a tray of puffed rice and sweets, and on returning saw that He was eating earth. In tears the Boy explained to her that sweets are the same earth, only in another form, and that He was being scolded for nothing. Shachi answered Him with a simple housewife's wisdom:

“‘When we eat earth in the form of food, it nourishes the body and gives us strength. But if we eat raw earth, the body will fall ill and perish. In a jug made of clay I can easily carry water, but if the water is poured out on the ground, it simply soaks in and all is wasted.’ The Lord replied: ‘Mother, why did you not tell Me this before? Now I understand and will not eat earth any more. When I am hungry, I would rather drink milk from your breast.’” (CC, Adi 14.31–34)

The men complained of His mischief to His father, and the girls and women to Shachi. The neighbours' daughters came to tell her how at the Ganga He splashed them with water, threw itching okada seeds into their hair and behaved exactly like the son of Nanda. Shachi smiled, embraced them tenderly and promised: “As soon as Nimai comes home, I will tie Him up and thrash Him with a stick”; the girls took the dust of her feet and went off to bathe (CB, Adi 6.72–85). And the parents, looking at their son, asked each other: “Who is this Child? Has the son of Nanda Himself been secretly born to us?” When Shachi scolded Him, He would run off in a temper and smash the pots at home, and then she would take Him on her lap, and Nimai, ashamed, would ask forgiveness (CC, Adi 14.41–44). Murari Gupta sees in this the same mystery as in Vraja:

“He whom Yashoda once bound with cattle ropes for a broken pot — Him Shachi now feared: looking at His face, she trembled.” (“Kadacha” 1.6.12)

Once, when His mother was scolding Him, the Boy struck her — according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” with His soft little hand, according to Lochana Dasa and Murari with a brick He threw. Shachi fell down as if unconscious — Lochana Dasa calls it a “feigned swoon”, for it was a play — and Nimai wept, “Mother, mother!” The neighbouring women advised Him: “Bring your mother two coconuts and she will come back to life,” and He at once brought two fresh coconuts, just picked; where a child had found them in a moment no one could understand (CC, Adi 14.45–47; “Kadacha” 1.6.20–30). Lochana Dasa says that Shachi then grasped for a moment who her son was:

“‘No one can measure my good fortune — not Brahma, nor Maheshvara, nor the other gods: this son of mine is the One whom all worship!’ Saying this, she took Gauraraya into her arms. But as soon as Shachi took Gaurahari into her arms, in her love for her son Shachi-devi forgot His majesty.” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 3, vv. 252–254)

So too Yashoda, after seeing the universe in Krishna's mouth, by His will once again saw in Him only her son: this is the working of yogamaya, which nourishes vatsalya, not worldly ignorance. And Shachi, who had just recognized Narayana in her son, ties a protective thread on Him and whispers over Him the names of Vishnu, praying them to guard His head, His eyes, His breast and His feet.

Once Nimai made friends with a puppy; Shachi scolded Him and told Him to give the dog away, and He wept before her in hurt. Then, singing the holy name, He granted the puppy a spiritual body, and it went to Vaikuntha; Shachi marvelled at her son's deeds, and little by little they revealed to her who He was. Another time she prepared an offering for the vow of the goddess Shashthi, the protectress of children, and Nimai intercepted her on the way and ate it. To her tears He replied that He is the essence of the three worlds and that, as watering the root nourishes the whole tree, so worship of Achyuta nourishes all the gods. Shachi, astonished, still went to Shashthi and, holding a blade of grass between her teeth in sign of humility, begged all the elder women to bless her son (CM, Adi-khanda, part 4, vv. 358–378):

“‘I have not many — this treasure Nimai you gave me out of mercy; let no misfortune befall my son — this boy is yours, O goddess!’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 4, v. 375)

When Nimai grew older, He went with His friends to bathe in the Ganga, and on coming back He would call out: “Mother, mother! Give Me scented oil, I want to go and bathe” — and Shachi was glad, seeing no trace of bathing on Him (CB, Adi 6.114–115). When He began to go to school, His six hours of lessons were like two yugas to His father and mother (CB, Adi 6.135). The same love that Shachi had for Nimai was felt by the neighbours: by Jagadisha and his wife Duhkhini, who was like a second mother to Him and sometimes even nursed Him, and by Srivasa and Malini, whom He accepted as a second father and mother. For Shachi's son is Yashoda's son Himself, Krishna.

Vishvarupa

The elder brother spent His days at Advaita's house, in discussions of the scriptures. When she had cooked the meal, Shachi would send the younger one to call Him:

“‘Dear brother, come and eat! Mother is calling You!’ Then Vishvambhara caught hold of the edge of Vishvarupa's dhoti, and the brothers went home.” (CB, Adi 7.40)

Advaita could not take His eyes off the beautiful Boy covered with dust, not yet recognizing in Him the One whom He had called with His weeping.[6]

When Vishvarupa reached youth — according to one biography, He was twelve — His father began to look for a bride for Him, and Vishvarupa secretly left home and took sannyasa (CC, Adi 15.11–12). The

parents' hearts were broken: day and night they called, “Vishvarupa! Vishvarupa!” (CB, Adi 7.74–80). In Lochana Dasa, Shachi, hearing the news, falls senseless and laments: how will He, so tender, walk the roads on foot, to whom will He now be wilful? — and Jagannatha consoles her: “If one in a family takes sannyasa, millions of generations are delivered.” And the mother replies:

“‘What did you say? Tell me again, my lord. “If one takes sannyasa, millions of generations are delivered”? Then my son has done well.’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 5, v. 452)

Murari Gupta says the same: the parents wept bitterly, but, wishing their son well, blessed Him: “May our son remain true to the dharma of sannyasa!” (“Kadacha” 1.7.7). So the mother's grief turned into a blessing. All the Vaishnavas of Navadvipa grieved, and Advaita and Sita consoled the parents and helped to bring up Nimai, repeating that Krishna Himself would soon come.

Nimai Himself consoled them:

“‘My brother has become a sannyasi, and this is a great blessing. For by this he will deliver his mother's family and his father's. In His place I will serve you.’ These words gladdened the hearts of His parents.” (CC, Adi 15.14–15)

Once He fell unconscious, and on coming to Himself related that Vishvarupa had called Him to take sannyasa, but He had reminded His brother that their parents needed help, and Vishvarupa had brought Him back and asked Him to convey “thousands of obeisances to mother Shachi” (CC, Adi 15.16–21). From then on Nimai was always beside His father and mother, dispelling their sorrow (CB, Adi 7.114).

Vishvarupa, who received in sannyasa the name Shankararanya, left this world in Pandharpur in 1509 (1431 of the Shaka era). The Lord learned of it many years later when, travelling in the South, He met in Pandharpur Sri Ranga Puri, a disciple of Madhavendra. Ranga Puri told Him that he had once been a guest with his guru at Jagannatha Mishra's house and still remembered the taste of the banana-flower curry the mistress of the house had cooked:

“Jagannatha Mishra's wife remained in his memory as a most devoted and chaste woman. She showed them such care, as if she were the mother of the whole universe.” (CC, Madhya 9.297)

“It seemed to him then that in all the three worlds no one could cook better than she. When she fed sannyasis, she treated them with the same love as her own sons.” (CC, Madhya 9.298)

Ranga Puri added that one of her worthy sons, Shankararanya, had attained perfection here in Pandharpur, and the Lord, overcome by separation, replied that before taking sannyasa Shankararanya had been His brother, and Jagannatha Mishra His father (CC, Madhya 9.299–301).[7]

Learning

Nimai learned with astonishing speed, and all Navadvipa vied in praising Him. Shachi heard this praise with joy, but Jagannatha grew gloomy: “Vishvarupa studied the scriptures, understood that the world is transient — and left. If Vishvambhara becomes learned, He too will leave home. Better that He remain unlettered but live with us.” Shachi objected:

“‘But how then will He be able to make a living? And who will give his daughter in marriage to an ignoramus?’” (CB, Adi 7.128)

Jagannatha replied that it is Krishna who feeds everyone, not learning, and insisted: the boy was forbidden to go to school (CB, Adi 7.121–148).[8] Lochana Dasa has another story too: when the father, angered by Nimai's pranks, took a switch in his hand, Shachi seized his arm, shielded her son with her body and hid Him in her lap:

“‘Do not beat my son — He is dying of fright!’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 6, v. 492)

Left without schooling, the Boy grew more mischievous than ever and one day sat down on a heap of discarded pots in which food had been cooked. His friends ran to Shachi, and she cried out: “Nimai, Nimai, what are You doing? One who touches these pots must bathe!” And He, like the sage Dattatreya, answered her from the top of this mound: I, an ignoramus, cannot tell good from bad; where I am, nothing is impure — the Ganga and all holy places come there; pots in which food was cooked for Vishnu cannot be defiled, and worldly notions of purity are mere figments of the imagination (CB, Adi 7.166–179; cf. CC, Adi 14.73–75; “Kadacha” 1.6.13–17). People laughed, and His mother pleaded:

“Shachimata said: ‘Come down and go and bathe.’ But the Lord did not move and went on sitting. ‘Nimai!’ said Shachimata. ‘Go quickly, before Your father finds out about Your pranks!’” (CB, Adi 7.181–182)

“I will not come down until you promise that I shall go to school again,” He answered, and the onlookers began to reproach Shachi: who had put it into her head to forbid her son to study when he himself wished to? At last Shachi pulled Him down from the pots, took Him to the Ganga, bathed Him and bathed herself, and when Jagannatha returned she told him everything:

“‘Our son is sad that He is not allowed to study.’” (CB, Adi 7.193)

All the neighbours supported her: “What Krishna wills will happen — let Him study,” and Jagannatha gave way: “As you say, so I shall do” (CB, Adi 7.183–197), and Nimai joyfully returned to His studies (7.202).

While still a child, Nimai asked His mother for a gift:

“Once, bowing at His mother's feet, Sri Chaitanya asked her for a single gift. His mother said: ‘I will do whatever You ask.’ Then Nimai said: ‘Please, mother, do not eat grain on Ekadashi.’ Shachi said: ‘Your words are true. I promise that I will no longer eat grain on Ekadashi.’ From then on she fasted on Ekadashi.” (CC, Adi 15.8–10)

Lochana Dasa says that He said it in a voice deep as thunder, and His mother's heart was filled with shyness, awe and love: “I shall keep Your command,” she said softly. Thus, by instructing His mother, the Lord taught everyone.

The Passing of Jagannatha

One day Jagannatha woke in tears and, bowing his head to the ground, began to pray to Govinda that Nimai might remain at home. Astonished, Shachi asked what he was praying for, and he told her his dream: Nimai with a shaven head, in the garb of a sannyasi, laughing, weeping and dancing with Krishna's name on His lips; the Vaishnavas, led by Advaita, singing around Him; He seated on the throne of Vishnu, Brahma and Shiva glorifying Him; and then He goes to Nilachala, and millions of people follow Him. Shachi calmed her husband:

“‘Do not worry,’ said Shachimata, ‘it is only a dream. Nimai will not leave home.’” (CB, Adi 8.106)

She tried to convince him that their son was too attached to His books to leave home, but she could not dispel her husband's anxiety (CB, Adi 8.93–108).

Soon Jagannatha left this world. Vrindavana Dasa says of him:

“But only a few days passed, and Jagannatha Mishra, whose body is eternal and transcendental, left this world.” (CB, Adi 8.109)

Lochana Dasa describes his last hours: when the fever began and Shachi wept, the Lord began to explain the truth to her — death is certain for all, even for Brahma and Rudra, time destroys Indra, Varuna and Agni — and told her to call the relatives so that all together might help His father remember

Krishna's name. Mother and son carried Jagannatha to the bank of the Ganga, and to the sound of sankirtana he departed for Vaikuntha. Shachi, clasping her husband's feet, wept: “I shall go with you! Take me with you!” The Lord grieved bitterly for His father, as Ramachandra did for Dasharatha, and then performed the prescribed rites for him (CM, Adi-khanda, part 8, vv. 657–691; CB, Adi 8.110; CC, Adi 15.23–24).

Only her love for her son helped Shachi to bear the loss. If she lost sight of Him even for a little while, her eyes grew dim, and He never left her side:

“‘Mother, do not grieve so,’ He would say, ‘as long as I am with you, you will want for nothing! Very soon I shall give you what is unattainable even for Brahma and Shiva.’ Seeing the beautiful face of Sri Gaurachandra, Shachi forgot not only her sufferings but herself.” (CB, Adi 8.117–119)

“Looking at Vishvambhara, you will forget everything,” the women consoled her. And she thought of one thing only: that her fatherless son should not fall into despondency; let His heart be immersed in learning — then He will be happy. She herself took Him to His teachers and humbly begged: “My son has lost His father — be kind to Him, regard Him as your own son”; the pandits, abashed, replied that it was they who would learn from Him (CM, Adi-khanda, part 8, vv. 687, 694–695; part 9, vv. 697–705). Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna took on the management of the widow's household.

They lived in poverty, but Nimai demanded of His mother all that only a King of kings could wish for, and when He did not get what He wanted, He grew angry. Once, about to go to the Ganga, He asked for a garland and sandal paste for the worship of the Ganga; His mother asked Him to wait a little — and He, flaring up like Rudra, smashed all the pots in the house, tore the cloth, broke the doors and began to beat with a stick the walls, the tree in the courtyard and the very ground. Shachi hid in a corner in fear: against His mother, says Vrindavana Dasa, He would not have raised His hand even in anger. Then He fell down in the courtyard and slept in the dust — He who reclines on Ananta. Shachi made the garland, gently brushed the sand from her son and raised Him up: “Get up, my son, go and worship the Ganga. It is good that You broke everything — now all misfortunes are behind us.” Abashed, He went silently to the river, while she tidied the house and sat down to cook:

“Although the Lord had destroyed everything in the house, there was no anxiety in Shachi's heart. She meekly bore all her son's outbursts, just as mother Yashoda bore Krishna's pranks in Gokula. Thus Shachi Devi, the mother of the universe, bore all the wilful outbursts of Sri Gauranga.” (CB, Adi 8.160–162)

“Mother Shachi, like mother Earth, patiently endured everything. Body, mind and speech were subject to her will.” (CB, Adi 8.164)

When He had come back from the Ganga and eaten, she only asked Him tenderly: “Why did You break so many things? All this is Yours, not mine. What will You eat tomorrow?” — and He answered with a smile: “Krishna takes care of everyone” (CB, Adi 8.123–171).

And indeed: returning one day from the Ganga, He called His mother aside and gave her two tolas of gold:

“‘Mother, look what Krishna has given us!’ said Nimai. ‘Go and exchange it for what we need.’” (CB, Adi 8.176)

This happened whenever want came to the house. Shachi marvelled and worried: where did her son get the gold — had He borrowed it? — and every time she exchanged it with great misgiving (CB, Adi 8.175–181).

Two Daughters-in-law

When Nimai had become a renowned pandita, Shachi resolved to see Him married. By the Lord's will, on the very day when He met at the Ganga Vallabhacharya's daughter Lakshmi, His eternal consort, the matchmaker Vanamali Acharya came to Shachi's house and proposed this girl as a wife for her son. But the mother replied:

"'My son is growing up without a father. Let Him first complete His education. When the time comes, I will think of His marriage.'" (CB, Adi 10.57)

Vanamali went away saddened and on the road met Nimai Himself. Having heard him, the Lord smiled and went home:

"Entering the house, the Lord asked His mother: 'Why did you turn down the brahmana's proposal?' Mother Shachi was delighted to hear her son's hint. The next day she called the brahmana to the house." (CB, Adi 10.63–64)

So also Lochana Dasa tells it: the Lord told His mother that He had seen the matchmaker looking sad, and "the very shrewd Shachi understood the hint" (CM, Adi-khanda, part 9, vv. 750–753). At her bidding Vanamali went to Vallabha; the poor brahmana could give with his daughter only "five haritaki fruits", but this troubled no one (CB, Adi 10.65–77; CC, Adi 15.29–30). Shachi invited relatives and friends, gave the women rice, bananas, kumkum, betel and oil, and in the evening, after the ceremony at Vallabha's house, she received the bride at the threshold together with the brahmanas' wives and lavishly rewarded the brahmanas and musicians (CB, Adi 10.87, 116–118).

With Lakshmi's coming Shachi's house became like Vaikuntha. It was flooded with such light that at times Shachi could not see anything clearly; beside her son she saw tongues of flame, and the fragrance of the lotus spread through the house:

"Shachi thought: 'I can guess the reason for this. Evidently my daughter-in-law is an incarnation of Lakshmi Devi. That is why I see this radiance and smell the fragrance of the lotus. Now our poverty will come to an end. How did I come to have such a daughter-in-law? Surely she is Lakshmi herself!'" (CB, Adi 10.124–126)

And indeed, the former poverty departed, and all that was needed appeared from no one knew where. When Nimai sat down to eat, His mother could not look enough at Lakshmi serving the rice and Him eating it (CB, Adi 12.102).

In those days Ishvara Puri came to Navadvipa, recognized by no one. Nimai invited him home for a meal, and Shachi cooked an offering for Krishna; having honoured the prasada, the guest sat in the Deity room and became absorbed in talk of Krishna (CB, Adi 11.92–94). Her son's studies, the happy days of His learning, were incomparable happiness for Shachi (CB, Adi 11.69).

Vrindavana Dasa relates how one full-moon night Nimai sat at the door of the Vishnu room and, remembering Vrindavana-chandra, began to play the flute. Only Shachi heard this melody: she fainted with rapture, and on coming to herself went out — and no longer heard the flute, but saw the full moon on her son's breast. At night she heard the singing of hundreds of voices, as though a rasa-lila were going on close by; she saw a light that filled the house, divine women with lotuses in their hands, radiant gods who vanished the next moment:

"There was nothing surprising in Shachi beholding all these wonders — the Vedas call her the embodiment of service to Lord Vishnu. Anyone on whom mother Shachi casts a merciful glance will be able to see the same wonders." (CB, Adi 12.230–231)

Sometimes the Lord invited ten or twenty sannyasis and sent word to His mother to cook at once a meal for twenty. "What shall I feed them with?" Shachi would worry if there was nothing in the house, but as soon as she thought of it, someone brought everything needed, and Lakshmi joyfully cooked (CB, Adi

14.14–19). Shachi saw how meek and diligent her daughter-in-law was, and her happiness grew day by day. Lakshmi rose at dawn, managed the house herself, decorated the floor of the Deity room with designs, prepared everything for the worship of Vishnu; she served Tulasi tirelessly, but still more gladly the Lord's mother. And when Lakshmi held her husband's feet in her hands for hours, Shachi at times saw around those feet a radiance like tongues of flame and smelt the fragrance of the lotus throughout the house (CB, Adi 14.38–47). “Her daughter-in-law's goodness makes Shachi forget herself,” says Lochana Dasa (CM, Adi-khanda, part 12, v. 107).

To support His mother and wife, the Lord went to teach in East Bengal. On leaving He said to His mother: “Mother, I am setting out on a journey,” and told Lakshmi to serve His mother constantly (CB, Adi 14.50–51). Lakshmi served “Ai” so, almost ceasing to eat; but separation from her husband she could not bear: “the snake of separation from Lord Chaitanya bit her, and the poison of that snake sent her to the supreme abode” (CC, Adi 16.21). On the bank of the Ganga, placing the Lord's feet in her heart, she left this world (CB, Adi 14.100–105). Shachi's grief, says Vrindavana Dasa, would have melted stones (CB, Adi 14.106). Lochana Dasa gives her lament: “My daughter-in-law Lakshmi was like Lakshmi in all her virtues… My son, having appointed you to serve me, went to foreign lands without a care — how shall I, unfortunate one, look at His face?” — and her relatives consoled her that the one eternal Reality is Krishna (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, vv. 122–136). The neighbours and all the devotees helped to perform the last rites.

Returning with rich gifts, the Lord bowed to His mother and offered her all He had brought; Shachi, sorrowful, at once began to cook. The relatives, not wishing to grieve Him, kept silent. Later He came to His mother:

“In reply to her son's words mother Shachi bowed her head and wept bitterly. Overcome by grief, she could not speak. The Lord said: ‘Dear mother, I know everything. Has some misfortune befallen your daughter-in-law?’” (CB, Adi 14.176–177)

The relatives told Him that Lakshmi had departed.[9] For a while the Lord was silent, grieving like an ordinary man, and then He consoled His mother: all creation is in the power of the Supreme — who but He unites and separates? And who is more fortunate than a woman who leaves her body before her husband? (CB, Adi 14.158–188). Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that He returned for this very purpose:

“As the Supreme Soul, Sri Chaitanya learned of Lakshmidevi's departure. He at once returned home to console His grieving mother.” (CC, Adi 16.22)

In Lochana Dasa and Murari Gupta the Lord consoles her with the story of an apsara cursed by Indra to be born on earth, who became the wife of an incarnation of God[10] — and Shachi, having listened to her son, “ceased grieving and thought of it no more” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, v. 157; “Kadacha” 1.12.8–18).

For a long time pain tormented Shachi's heart, but in time she began to think of her son's happiness and searched all Navadvipa for a new bride for Him. Vishnupriya, the daughter of the raja-pandita Sanatana Mishra, she had known long: from childhood the girl bathed in the Ganga several times a day and each time bowed humbly to Shachi.

“And mother Shachi lovingly blessed her: ‘May Lord Krishna send you a worthy husband.’ While bathing, Shachi thought: ‘How good it would be if this girl became my son's wife.’” (CB, Adi 15.48–49)

Having made sure that her son did not object, Shachi called the brahmana Kashinatha and, opening her heart to him in private, sent him to Sanatana: “Tell him: if he wishes, let him give his daughter to my son” (CB, Adi 15.38–52; CM, Adi-khanda, part 13; “Kadacha” 1.13.2–3).[11] It is told that she worried lest Sanatana, a man of high standing, reject her son, who was not rich and whom the town thought

eccentric, but the matchmaker only answered: “Thakurani, if not to Nimai Pandita, then to whom?” — and when he came back from Sanatana and told her everything, he heard: “I have done what I could; the rest is in the hands of Sri Hari.” Sanatana and his family gladly agreed, and the mother, delighted, at once began to prepare for the wedding (CB, Adi 15.60–67). And when Sanatana sent his messenger to her, Shachi replied:

“‘Good, good!’ said Shachi in great joy. ‘I agree; do everything quickly.’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, v. 38)

The brahmana messenger added that Vishnupriya would justify her name — she would obtain Vishvambhara as Rukmini obtained Krishna — and the mother rejoiced still more (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, vv. 39–42; “Kadacha” 1.13.10–15).

On the eve of the wedding Shachi with the women performed puja to the Ganga, went with music to worship the goddess Shashthi, visited the houses of relatives and lavishly gave the women puffed rice, bananas, oil, betel and kumkum:

“By the presence of the Supreme Lord the quantity of prepared gifts kept increasing. Thus mother Shachi was able to present each of the women five or seven times.” (CB, Adi 15.118)

Setting out for the bride's house, the Lord reverently walked around His mother and bowed to her and to the brahmanas (CB, Adi 15.140). When the newly-weds were returning in a palanquin through the streets of Navadvipa, the women compared them, some to Shiva and Parvati, some to Lakshmi and Hari, some to Kama and Rati, some to Indra and Shachi, some to Rama and Sita; and at the house Shachi was waiting with the virtuous women — she warmly greeted her daughter-in-law and led her into the house (CB, Adi 15.205–213; “Kadacha” 1.14.33). From then on, says Murari, the Lord lived at home, gladdening His mother and wife (“Kadacha” 1.15).

Then the Lord performed the shraddha for His father and prepared to go to Gaya. He asked His mother's permission (CB, Adi 17.12), and her heart was set aflame:

“‘You are going to foreign lands — listen, Vishvambhara: without You there is darkness in my house. You are the blind woman's staff, the pupil of my eyes, the soul of this body — I have no one but You.’” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 15, vv. 11–12)

He consoled her with sweet words and left. And when He returned and bowed at her feet, Shachi embraced her son, and tears of love and joy streamed from her eyes (CM, Adi-khanda, part 15, vv. 14, 105–106). But it was a different Nimai who had come back from Gaya.

The Son Returned from Gaya

Shachi looked at her son and forgot herself for joy (CB, Madhya 1.18). But what had happened to Him she could not understand. He wept aloud, calling for Krishna, flooding the courtyard with His tears, and asked everyone, “Where is Krishna? Where is Krishna?” With folded palms the mother begged Govinda to protect her son (1.43–46), and then went to worship the Ganga and Vishnu:

“Mother Shachi prayed: ‘O Krishnachandra! You have taken my husband and my children. Only one son is left to me. O Krishna! There is no one to protect me. Please grant me the blessing that Vishvambhara may go on living at home, in His right mind.’” (CB, Madhya 1.135–136)

She would bring Vishnupriya and seat her beside her son, but He seemed not to see even His wife; when He began to cry out, Vishnupriya would run away in fright and Shachi would be numb with fear (1.137–139). One day at the meal she set before Him rice adorned with a tulasi leaf and, like any mother, asked what He had been reading that day and whether He had quarrelled with anyone. Vrindavana Dasa, describing that moment, calls her “Shachi, the mother of all creation”: in answer the

Lord, as Kapila once spoke to His mother Devahuti, began to tell her of the glory of devotional service to Krishna and of the torments of the soul that forgets Krishna — in the mother's womb, at birth and after it — and that only one who worships Krishna in the company of His devotees can live and die without fear. Listening to Him, Shachi felt great bliss (CB, Madhya 1.189–241).

But the change in her son kept growing. He laughed and wept, fell unconscious, talked to Himself, and Shachi decided it was some unknown illness. “By the will of Providence I have lost my husband and my children; I have no one but my son,” she told everyone, “and I cannot understand what is wrong with Him: now He laughs, now He weeps.” The neighbours advised her to tie Him up, to give Him the juice of green coconuts, to rub oil into His head, and “the magnanimous Shachi, the Mother of the universe”, not knowing what to do, tried to follow their advice and surrendered herself wholeheartedly to Govinda. She sent word of everything to the Vaishnavas headed by Srivasa, and one day Srivasa came. The Lord was then circumambulating tulasi; on seeing the devotee He fell unconscious, and when He came to Himself He sobbed. “Is this madness?” thought Srivasa. “This is the highest devotion to Krishna.” To the mother he said:

“‘Do not worry about anything. I assure you, this is not madness but true devotion to Krishna. No one is able to understand it. If you wish to see still more of Krishna's wonders, tell nothing to outsiders.’” (CB, Madhya 2.120–122)

Shachi gave up the thought of madness, but anxiety did not leave her: would not this son, too, leave home? (CB, Madhya 2.88–124)

Once the Lord asked Gadadhara where that dark Krishna in yellow garments was, and on hearing, “Krishna is always in Your heart,” began to tear at His chest with His nails. Gadadhara held His hands and calmed Him: “Be patient, Krishna will come soon.” Shachi saw it all. “I have never met so sensible a youth,” she thought. “I myself am afraid even to go near my son, and he has calmed Him so skilfully,” and she asked him, “Dear boy, stay always by my son; do not leave Him for a moment.” Seeing such love of God in Him, she could no longer think of Him as her son: “An ordinary man cannot shed such tears. What great soul has appeared in our family?” — and in awe she did not dare to show herself before Him (CB, Madhya 2.202–214). Thus for a moment the Lord's majesty veiled her motherly love; but each time vatsalya, guarded by yogamaya, prevailed, and to her He was again only her son.

Soon the mother herself received what He had brought from Gaya. Krishnadasa Kaviraja says it in a single line:

“Then He bestowed love of Krishna upon His mother Shachidevi.” (CC, Adi 17.10)

Lochana Dasa tells how it happened. Once, lying at home, the Lord wept in the mood of Radha separated from Krishna, who had gone away to Mathura, and gave no answer to His mother's questions. Shachi reflected — and by the signs understood that this was prema, Krishna's grace. Then she said:

“‘Listen, listen, my son, my golden son: I see in You a wondrous [treasure], rare in the world. Wherever You went, whatever wealth You obtained, You brought it and gave it to me. In Gaya You obtained such wealth — love for Krishna, a thing rare even for the gods, a priceless jewel. If there is any compassion for me in Your heart, give me the wealth of love for Krishna — this I ask.’ When Shachi-devi spoke such words, the Lord's heart melted, and He looked [at her]: ‘By the mercy of the Vaishnavas you will obtain prema, mother — know it for certain: I am telling you.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 1, vv. 26–31)

At once Shachi obtained prema-bhakti: her body trembled, tears streamed from her eyes, and she called, “Krishna, Krishna!” (vv. 32–34). Murari Gupta tells it the same way: the mother saw her son weeping in His sleep, in time recognised the signs of prema and humbly begged Him for it; the Lord answered,

“Mother, by the mercy of the Vaishnavas this will come to be for you,” and Shachi, “devotion personified”, obtained firm devotion to Hari (“Kadacha” 2.1.9–18).[12]

Lochana Dasa tells of another night too. In the third watch Vishvambhara suddenly began to weep, and Shachi, waking, asked, “Why are You weeping, child? Hearing Your weeping, I burn all over.” He was long silent, and then, sitting up on the bed, told her His dream: He had seen a Youth shining like a fresh raincloud, with a crest of peacock feathers, in yellow garments and with a flute in His hand. “Do not tell anyone,” He asked, and the mother rejoiced at these nectarean words (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 6, vv. 5–13).

Two Sons

In those years a joy came to dwell in Shachi's house such as she had not known before: once more she had two sons. At the Vyasa-puja in Srivasa's house, when Nityananda and Gaurachandra, intoxicated with dancing, forgot Themselves, Shachi watched Them from a secluded place:

“When mother Shachi looked at Vishvambhara and Nityananda, she thought: ‘These are my sons.’” (CB, Madhya 5.159)

Nityananda often came running to her, and she welcomed Him with great love, while He, like a mischievous child, tried to catch hold of her feet, and she would run away (CB, Madhya 8.26–27). Once, towards morning, she had a dream and told it to her son in private: He and Nityananda, both five years old, ran into the Deity room, carried out Krishna and Balarama and began to quarrel with Them over the offerings. “The time when You stole butter is past,” Nityananda was saying, “now is the time of the brahmanas. My Master is Gaurachandra Vishvambhara.” All four snatched the food from one another, and then Nityananda called to her, “Mother, give Me something to eat, I am hungry.” The Lord laughed: “Mother, this is a most auspicious dream, only do not tell anyone about it. I Myself have noticed that half of what is offered to our Deities disappears somewhere.” And He proposed that they invite Nityananda to a meal at once (CB, Madhya 8.28–51).[13]

Shachi gladly set about cooking, the Lord Himself went to fetch Nityananda, and Ishana, the servant of the house, brought water to wash Their feet (8.52–59). The brothers sat side by side, and Vrindavana Dasa compares Them to Rama and Lakshmana in the house of Kaushalya:

“Mother Shachi joyfully served Them, and when by mistake she brought Them three plates instead of two, They laughed merrily. And when she brought Them more, she saw Them in the form of five-year-old boys. She saw two beautiful boys, one fair-skinned and the other dark. They wore no clothes, and both had four arms. One held in His hands the conch, the disc, the club and the lotus, and on His chest were the mark of Shrivatsa and the Kaustubha gem. The other held the club and the plough. In the ears of both were earrings shaped like makaras.” (CB, Madhya 8.62–65)

On her son's chest she saw her daughter-in-law too, like Lakshmi on the chest of Narayana — and the vision vanished. Shachi fell unconscious, the food scattered about the room; the Lord lifted her up, and she, saying nothing, went away into another room all in tears (8.66–71).

The remnants of that meal were cleared away and reverently eaten by Ishana:

“He is the most fortunate in all the fourteen worlds, for all his life he served mother Shachi.” (CB, Madhya 8.74)

Ishana did whatever she needed, and Shachi loved him dearly. Serving her who is non-different from Yashoda, he knew that service to a devotee is higher than worship of the Lord Himself, and that the Lord is merciful to one whom His devotee has blessed first. “With folded palms I bow to Ishana, whom Shachi Thakurani loved so dearly,” sings the “Vaishnava-vandana”.

Shachi regarded Nityananda as her own Vishvarupa: more than once she had heard Him speak exactly like her elder son, and had even seen Him in the form of Vishvarupa, but she told no one of this. When Nityananda, like a child, stood unclothed in the middle of the courtyard and the Lord Himself dressed Him, the mother beamed with smiles. Once she gave Him five sandesh; He ate one and threw the rest away. “Why did You throw them away? What will You eat now?” Shachi lamented. “If you want, you will find them,” He replied. Going into the room, she found there the same four sandesh, and on coming back she saw Nityananda eating them:

“Shachi said: ‘O Nityananda, why do You bewilder me? I know that You are the Supreme Lord, and so I pray You to free me from the veil of illusion.’” (CB, Madhya 11.92)

By “the veil of illusion” she humbly means yogamaya, which hides from her the majesty of her sons. And He, like a child, reached again for her feet, and she ran away (CB, Madhya 11.78–93). Lochana Dasa relates that the Lord Himself revealed to her, “This is Vishvarupa, your own son; under the name of Nityananda He has come to Navadvipa,” and the mother, embracing Nityananda, said, “You have become my son… from today you two are my sons.” “All that you have said, mother, is true: I am your son — know it for certain,” answered Nityananda, and “seeing her two sons, Shachi was comforted at heart” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 5, vv. 80+10–80+11, 81–90).[14]

At home the Lord spent time with Vishnupriya, for He knew that this gladdened His mother (CB, Madhya 11.67–68). But more and more the house became for Him a place of ecstasy. His mother would say, “Son, go and bathe in the Ganga,” and He would answer, “Mother, chant the names of Rama and Krishna”;

“Whatever Shachi said to her son, Vishvambhara answered only, ‘Krishna.’” (CB, Madhya 8.94)

Watching this, she was immersed in bliss, but in the depths of her heart she thought that this son too might leave home (8.92). When in kirtana His tender body fell heavily to the ground, she would close her eyes, call on Govinda and pray, “O Krishna, let me not see Vishvambhara falling to the ground.” The Lord felt His mother's wish — and immersed her in such bliss that while the kirtana went on she was unaware of the outer world (8.124–132). When the Lord delivered Jagai and Madhai, Shachi and her daughter-in-law watched His pastimes at home, sunk in an ocean of nectar (13.308, 372), and Vrindavana Dasa exclaims:

“Who can describe the good fortune that fell to mother Shachi? Only the thousand-headed Lord Ananta is able to, and even He only if He receives inspiration from above.” (CB, Madhya 13.373)

“Gazing at the lotus face of her son, Shachi, the Mother of the universe, forgot where she was.” (CB, Madhya 13.375)

Together with her daughter-in-law she prayed to Govinda as she beheld her son, and was wholly filled with bliss (CB, Madhya 19.270).

In the House of Chandrashekhara

When the Lord resolved to play the role of Lakshmi in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya, her sister's husband, Shachi and her daughter-in-law came to watch, and with them the families of all the Vaishnavas (CB, Madhya 18.28–30). Srivasa came out in the guise of Narada — the same form, the same words and manners. “Is that Srivasa?” Shachi asked Malini. “Yes, it is he,” she replied. And Shachi, “a great Vaishnavi and the mother of the whole universe”, fainted with bliss, so that no sign of life could be found in her body; the women whispered the names of Krishna in her ear, and on coming to herself she remembered Govinda (18.62–68). And when the Lord Himself came out, no one recognised Him, not even those who had known Him from birth:

“What to speak of others, when even mother Shachi did not recognise Him. She said: ‘Can it be that Lakshmi herself has come to dance?’” (CB, Madhya 18.131)

And when the play was over and all were weeping with love of God, the pious women fell at Shachi's feet (18.197).

Shachi and Advaita

Even in Nimai's childhood Shachi used to send Him to Advaita's house to call Vishvarupa to the meal, and Advaita, looking at the beautiful Child, would think, “He has stolen My heart — so this is My Lord” (CB, Madhya 22.93–102). But for the mother Advaita's house became a house of loss: there Vishvarupa had found the love for Krishna with which He left for sannyasa. “It was Advaita who induced my son to leave,” she would think when the pain subsided, but, fearing to offend a Vaishnava, she told this to no one, and looking at Vishvambhara she forgot her sorrows (22.107–110). Now Vishvambhara too spent nearly all His time with Advaita, leaving His young wife at home,[15] and one day her grief broke out:

“When mother Shachi saw that her son was hardly ever at home, she said: ‘Acharya Gosani will take this son away too.’ In deep sorrow she went on: ‘Why do they call him “Advaita”? In truth this Gosani is “Dvaita”. He has already induced one son of mine to leave home, and now he wants to deprive me of my other son. I am a widow. No one will take pity on me.’” (CB, Madhya 22.113–117)

No one learned of this except her Son, who dwells in the heart of everyone.

One day the Lord sat on Vishnu's throne in Srivasa's house and began to give the devotees blessings. Srivasa asked Him to grant love of Krishna to mother Shachi — and heard: “Do not ask this. She has offended a Vaishnava, and that keeps her from attaining prema.” “Your words wound us to death,” cried Srivasa. “How can she who gave birth to You not attain love of Krishna?” The Lord answered that it was not in His power to destroy an offence against a Vaishnava — only that Vaishnava himself could do so, as Ambarisha forgave Durvasa; let His mother place on her head the dust of Advaita's feet (22.13–36).[16] The devotees went to Advaita, and He exclaimed:

“‘Do you all want to kill Me? My Lord came forth from her womb, and therefore she is My mother and I am her son. I Myself long to obtain the dust of her feet. I do not even know the limits of My mother's glory. She is the mother of the whole universe and the embodiment of loving service to Vishnu. So how can you say such a thing? Even if a person utters “ai” as an ordinary word, the divine power of that sound will free him from all suffering. Mother Shachi is exactly like the Ganga. In truth, she is equal to Devaki and Yashoda.’” (CB, Madhya 22.38–43)

Glorifying her, Advaita lost consciousness, and at that moment Shachi took the dust of His feet — and herself fell unconscious with bliss. The Vaishnavas began to sing the names of Hari, and the Lord, pleased with His mother, said to her from the throne:

“‘Now you have attained devotional service to Vishnu, freed from the offence you committed against Advaita.’” (CB, Madhya 22.52)

Vrindavana Dasa himself adds a caution: “In truth, it was not even an offence, but the Lord took it so” (CB, Madhya 22.58). The mother's words were the lament of vatsalya, not abuse; and the Lord enacted this pastime for the sake of others. He knew that there would be people who, exalting one Vaishnava, would disregard the rest, and through the example of His own mother, “as the instructing spiritual master”, He warned everyone against vaishnava-aparadha (22.54, 118–131). If He did not pardon even His mother — the very essence of motherly love, Yashoda — what can others expect? One can be freed from an offence against a Vaishnava only by asking forgiveness of that Vaishnava himself. But Shachi

too set an example: having given birth to Gaurahari, she was not in the least proud, and on understanding her fault she went to Advaita without delay.

Before the Sannyasa

The anxiety that Shachi had carried in her heart ever since her son's return from Gaya was gradually taking shape. Lochana Dasa relates that once a certain brahmana, who had not been let in to watch the Lord's dancing, cursed Him in anger: “Be outside samsara!” Hearing of it from people, Shachi fell unconscious, and when her son came home she asked Him in tears, “How did you wrong him? This whole house of mine is only for your sake… if harm comes to you, I shall die.” “I have done him no wrong,” the Lord consoled her, “and a curse without fault cannot take effect.” He bathed in the Ganga, worshipped Krishna, watered tulasi and sat down to eat, while Shachi tenderly gazed at His face (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 10, vv. 69+1–21).[17] But for Him this curse was a blessing: He Himself wished to leave samsara. Soon, with a quiet smile, He told those close to Him that in the night a brahmana had whispered the mantra of sannyasa in His ear, and since then His heart was no longer His own (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 12, vv. 49–53).[18]

The first to learn of the Lord's decision was Nityananda, and among the five to whom the Lord allowed Him to disclose it, His mother was named first (CB, Madhya 28.11–12). Thinking of how she would bear this separation, Nityananda went off to a solitary place and wept bitterly (CB, Madhya 26.153–156). Shachi herself wept at home, seeing her son in ecstasy embracing the devotees and sobbing (26.84). And when the news reached her, she forgot where she was, fell unconscious again and again and could not stop her tears (CB, Madhya 27.18–20), and one day, when her son was sitting at home, she said to Him:

“‘My dear son, do not leave home. Do not abandon Your mother. This sinful soul lives only because she sees Your face.’” (CB, Madhya 27.22)

“‘You have descended to establish religious principles, but is leaving one's mother a religious precept? You are the embodiment of all religious rules, so how will You leave Your mother? How then will You preach religious precepts in this world?’” (CB, Madhya 27.27–28)

“Your elder brother left me, Your father has gone to Vaikuntha; stay, sing kirtana at home with Your devotees — Nityananda will help You,” she pleaded (27.30–34), and Vrindavana Dasa compares her to Kaushalya instructing Rama (27.35). The Lord was silent, His head bowed. Shachi grew pale, stopped eating, and from grief her body became “skin and bones”. Then, seeing that His mother could not go on living like this, the Lord took her aside to a solitary place:

“The Lord said: ‘My mother, restore peace to your soul and understand that I have been your son for many lives. Hear attentively of your own glory. In the past your name was Prishni. You were My mother. Later you appeared in the heavens as Aditi. I descended into this world as Vamana, and you were My mother. Then you came as Devahuti, and I was born as your son Kapila. Then you became Kaushalya, and I came again as your son Ramachandra. Then you were born as Devaki in Mathura and were imprisoned by the demon Kamsa. At that time too you became My mother. You are that same Devaki, and I am your son. Beginning this movement of sankirtana, I shall soon take two more births as your son. My mother, in My form as the Deity you appear as the earth. And in My form as the holy name you are My mother as the tongue. You are My mother birth after birth. Nothing will ever separate you and Me.’” (CB, Madhya 27.39–49)

Thus the Lord revealed to her that He would be her son hereafter as well — in the Deity, which is made from earth, and in the holy name, which the tongue sings: the name, the form and the very being of the Lord are non-different from one another. Hearing this secret, Shachi found peace (27.36–51).

Lochana Dasa tells the same in his own way. Shachi begged her son not to take sannyasa in His youth, and He told her of Dhruva and of the instruction of his mother. “I too will go with you,” said Shachi then. “If such a golden son goes off with a shaven head, I will shave my head, put on red garments and become a yogini.” The Lord began to console her: other people's sons bring their mothers gold and silver, which pass away, but He would bring her prema for Krishna, imperishable in this world and the next. And for a moment the Lord of the fourteen worlds lifted the veil from her: in her son she saw Krishna of Vrindavana, dark as a fresh cloud, with His flute, among the cowherd boys and gopis. Yet even then the mother's love did not yield to His majesty:

“[Yet] in her tenderness Shachi does not give up her own relation [to Him]: ‘Krishna has become my son — so my good fortune has decreed. Krishna, unattainable for the world, is my son; He is subject to no one's control — what can my strength do?’ Reasoning thus, Shachi spoke: ‘You are the independent Lord, the jewel among men. By my good fortune You were so long in my power — now, as it pleases You, take sannyasa.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 14, vv. 212–215)

“Why is such a treasure leaving me?” she asked and wept aloud, and the Lord, raising His face, answered:

“‘…on any day when you long with love to see Me — at that very moment you will be able to see Me.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 14, v. 220)

The veil lifted from her at that moment Lochana Dasa calls maya, but it is no veil of ignorance: it is yogamaya, the Lord's internal potency, which hides His majesty for the sake of a mother's love — and, having seen that majesty, Shachi still remained His mother.

On the eve of His departure the pious Shridhara brought the Lord a gourd. “Tomorrow I shall leave,” thought the Lord, “but nothing Shridhara brings must go to waste,” and He asked His mother to cook it, and when another devotee brought a pitcher of milk, He said with a smile, “Very good, cook them together.” Shachi set about the cooking with great joy (CB, Madhya 28.33–40). Vrindavana Dasa places this departure beside others: Kapila left His mother Devahuti, Shuka went away from his father, the great Vaishnava Vyasa, without looking back, and the best of sannyasis left His mother Shachi; but “in truth all these examples of renunciation are not a forsaking of one's obligations. At their root lies the attainment of the highest good, but only great souls can understand this” (CB, Madhya 3.101–104).

The Night of Departure

That night Shachi did not sleep but only wept. The Lord woke in the brahma-muhurta, and when she understood that He was about to leave, she came and sat by the door. The Lord took her by the hands:

“‘You cared for Me wonderfully. Only thanks to you did I master the sciences and receive an education. Forgetting your own happiness, you live only for My pleasure. Every moment you gave Me such love that I cannot repay you even in a million kalpas.’” (CB, Madhya 28.51–53)

“‘My dear mother, please hear Me. All creation is governed by the Supreme Lord. No one has the power to be independent. Who can understand the will of the Supreme Lord, by which living beings meet and part? Whether I leave now or in ten years, you should not grieve in any case. I take full responsibility for both your worldly and your spiritual needs.’” (CB, Madhya 28.55–58)

“Mother Shachi listened quietly to what the Lord was saying. She answered nothing; only endless tears streamed from her eyes. Thus Shachi, the mother of the whole universe, became as sorrowful and silent as mother Earth. Can anyone comprehend the inconceivable pastimes of Krishna? The Lord placed the dust of His mother's feet on His head, walked around her and left without delay.” (CB, Madhya 28.60–62)

In the morning the devotees came to bow to the Lord and found His mother at the door. “Why are you sitting here, mother?” asked Srivasa. For a long time she could not speak, and then she said:

“After some time she said: ‘Listen to me. Only the Vaishnavas have the right to share the Lord's possessions. Divide among yourselves all that He has left. The shastras say that all this now belongs to you. So take it, do as I ask, and let me go away from here.’” (CB, Madhya 28.70–72)

The Lord's house was filled with weeping, and when the devotees had calmed down a little, they sat around mother Shachi (28.65–88).

This parting was no rupture in the worldly sense. The Lord did not leave His mother as people leave their families for their own sake: He went for the deliverance of the fallen (28.63), and in leaving took upon Himself the care of her. And her grief is vipralambha, separation, in which a mother's love is revealed most fully; so Yashoda wept for Krishna when Akrura took Him away to Mathura.

Twelve Days

When the news reached Navadvipa, “mother Shachi turned to stone with grief. She stood motionless, like a doll” (CB, Antya 1.38). Lochana Dasa says that Shachi and Vishnupriya kept falling unconscious; Shachi wept, holding on her lap Vishnupriya, who lay as if dead, and called, “Nimai!” — “All around is empty, all is shrouded in darkness… no one will call me ‘mother’ any more” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 16, vv. 8–15). As He left to follow the Lord to Katva, Nityananda consoled them both (v. 44). Then, remembering His words, “Whoever chants the name will attain Me,” all of them — Shachi and Vishnupriya, children and the old, young men and girls — sat down to chant the holy name, making Gauranga their refuge. The devotees, finding consolation only in the names and qualities of the Lord, did not leave Shachi's side (CB, Antya 1.50). For four days, while the Lord, beside Himself with love, wandered through Radha-desha, yearning for Vrindavana, Sita was with her: Shachi, exhausted by separation, could not rise from the ground and scarcely showed a sign of life. And Vamshivadana composed a song of separation in which the poet rolls on the ground, hearing the weeping of the Lord's young wife and her mother-in-law.

When Chandrashekhara came back from Katva, Shachi ran out to meet him with her hair unbound:

“‘Where have you left my Nimai and come back? How did He shave His head, in what land? What wretched sannyasi with a cruel heart felt no pity when giving the mantra to Vishvambhara!’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 6–7)

“No more shall I cook rice to serve you… Who will know when you are hungry?” she lamented (vv. 12–13). These are the words of a mother's love, not abuse of the guru of the Lord's sannyasa: so speaks the heart of a mother for whom her Son is her whole life.

Meanwhile the Lord had sent Nityananda to Navadvipa to tell the devotees that He awaited them in Shantipur, in Advaita's house (CB, Antya 1.127–133). Nityananda, intoxicated with prema, swam down the Ganga to the Lord's favourite ghat and went straight to His house:

“On arriving, He saw that mother Shachi had been fasting for twelve days already. Only by the strength of her devotion to Krishna did she remain alive. Mother Shachi was overflowing with the parental love of Yashoda. Tears of love streamed endlessly from her eyes. Whomever she met, mother Shachi asked: ‘Are you from Mathura? Please, tell me, how are Krishna and Balarama there?’ Asking this, she would fall unconscious to the ground. Sometimes mother Shachi said: ‘Are those the sounds of the flute and the horn? Has Akrura at last come back to Vrindavana?’ Thus mother Shachi was sinking in the ocean of separation from Krishna. Not a trace of outer consciousness remained in her body.” (CB, Antya 1.146–151)

This is not bewilderment but prema itself: in separation from Gaura there was revealed in Shachi who she eternally is — Yashoda waiting for Krishna to come back from Mathura. Nityananda fell at her feet, and with a cry of "My son!" she lost consciousness. He gave everyone the good news and began to console her: "Your son is the Supreme Lord Himself, whom the Vedas seek. He has promised always to protect you and to care for all your needs, both material and spiritual" (1.152–168). And He added:

"'Mother, let us go quickly. You will cook for Krishna and so satisfy all the devotees. Everyone wishes to taste the food cooked by you. But when you fast, Krishna fasts too. Cook some dish and offer it to Krishna. I am very hungry.'" (CB, Antya 1.169–171)

"Hearing these words of Nityananda, mother Shachi forgot her sorrows and went to cook. The pious mother Shachi first offered the dish she had cooked to Krishna, and then served it to Nityananda. Then mother Shachi served all the Vaishnavas, feeding them prasada. All were happy to taste it. When all the devotees were satisfied, mother Shachi herself sat down to eat, breaking her twelve-day fast." (CB, Antya 1.172–175)

Shantipur

Lochana Dasa describes her meeting with Nityananda thus: with a cry of "O Avadhuta, where have you left my Nimai?" Shachi, mad with grief, ran to meet Him, and Nityananda answered, "Do not grieve: He has sent me to bring you all. The Lord will be in the house of Advaita Acharya — let us go!" At once everyone set out — from children to the old — and Shachi ran ahead of them all: strength had returned to her body (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 56–64). Murari Gupta writes that Nityananda bowed at Shachi's feet, consoled her, ate the food she had cooked, and next morning led her and the Vaishnavas to Advaita's house ("Kadacha" 3.4.8–10). With her went Murari Gupta, Nandana Acharya, Shridhara, Damodara Pandita and many others; Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that it was Chandrashekhara who went to fetch her:[19]

"On the morning after Mahaprabhu's arrival Chandrashekhara brought mother Shachi in a palanquin. Many other devotees came with them too." (CC, Madhya 3.137)

"The Lord fell before her in obeisance. Mother Shachi laid His head on her lap and burst into sobs. The meeting shook them both. Seeing her son's smoothly shaven head, Shachimata was deeply agitated. With great love she stroked her son and kissed His face. She tried to look at Him, but tears blinded her eyes. Sobbing, Shachi lamented: 'My dear son, Nimai! Do not become as cruel as Vishvarupa, Your elder brother. I have not seen him since he took sannyasa. You will kill me if You do the same.'" (CC, Madhya 3.140–144)

"Sri Chaitanya answered with tears in His eyes: 'O My mother, hear Me. My body is all I have, and it belongs to you. It was born and nurtured by you. Even in millions of births I could not repay you this debt. I shall never become indifferent to you, whatever aims I pursued in taking sannyasa. I shall live wherever you say and fulfil your every wish.'" (CC, Madhya 3.145–148)

Seeing her son in the garments of a sannyasi, Shachi and all the people of Navadvipa felt joy mingled with the pain of separation. Murari recalls His words: "Mother, I am always near you" ("Kadacha" 3.4.21); according to Lochana Dasa, the Lord fell before her and said, "Weep no more: your weeping pains My heart" (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 76+3–4).[20]

From that day it was Shachi herself who cooked for the Lord and His companions (CC, Madhya 3.160), and He ate what she had prepared, to soothe at least a little the pain His departure had caused her. At night, when He fell to the ground in kirtana, the mother wept and prayed:

"'O Narayana! From childhood I have done my every act and every deed as service to You. Please grant my request. Each time my Nimai falls to the ground, let Him feel no pain at all.'" (CC, Madhya 3.165–166)

Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that in her at that time happiness, fear and humility were joined together (3.167). When Srivasa and other brahmanas also wished to invite the Lord to their homes for a meal, Shachi asked them:

"'Who knows where and when I shall see Nimai again? You will always be able to meet Him in another place. But my lot is sad — for I have only this meeting. Therefore I beg you all, let me cook for Nimai while He stays in the house of Sri Advaita.'" (CC, Madhya 3.169–171)

A sannyasi ought not to live among his relatives, but the Lord said that He would leave neither the devotees nor His mother, and asked how He might fulfil both dharmas. Advaita and the devotees came to Shachi with this question, and the Mother of the universe decided it herself:

"'If He stays here, He will make me happy. But if people censure Him, I shall be unhappy. So I have a fine idea. Let Him settle in Jagannatha Puri. In this way He will attain both aims at once. Navadvipa is closely connected with Jagannatha Puri. People are always going back and forth, and so I shall always have the latest news. You will easily be able to go there, and sometimes He too will come to bathe in the Ganga. It does not matter to me at all whether I am happy or not. But whatever brings Him happiness gives happiness to me too.'" (CC, Madhya 3.181–185)

"O mother, your words are like the injunctions of the Vedas," the devotees replied (3.186).[21] The Lord, delighted, asked everyone at home to perform Krishna-sankirtana unceasingly (3.187–191). The festival at Advaita's house went on for several days more: by day they spoke of Krishna, by night they sang, the mother cooked in bliss, and her son and the devotees partook of her cooking, and her happiness grew day by day (3.198–205); in all the Lord stayed ten days in Shantipur (3.136). Advaita asked Nityananda, Jagadananda, Damodara Pandita and Mukunda Datta to accompany Him to Puri.[22]

Lochana Dasa describes the farewell. The devotees pleaded, "Look at Your defenceless mother… How will You take leave of Shachi?" Shachi, her strength gone, rose, holding on to the hands of two people:

"'Where will you go, having become pitiless? Not seeing you, my son, I shall die. Everyone else will see your face many times — but I, unfortunate, shall see it no more. You yourself, child, have consoled everyone — but who, my son, will console me?'" (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 19, vv. 56–58)

"You are dying of vain grief, forgetting what you knew before," the Lord answered, reminding her who her son is, and, prostrating Himself at her feet, consoled her (vv. 60–62). Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that on leaving the Lord offered prayers at His mother's feet and reverently walked around her, and Advaita's house was filled with weeping (CC, Madhya 3.210–211). So in 1510 He left by way of Chhatrabhoga for Nilachala.

News from Puri

In the first years of separation Shachi lived on news. When the Lord returned from His long journey through the south, Nityananda, Jagadananda, Mukunda and Damodara decided that before all else mother Shachi must be told, and with the Lord's permission they sent Kala Krishnadasa to Bengal with maha-prasada (CC, Madhya 10.67–74). In Bengal he went to her first of all:

"He bowed respectfully before her and gave her the maha-prasada, and then told her of Sri Chaitanya's return from His pilgrimage through South India. This news brought inexpressible joy to Shachimata and to all the Vaishnavas headed by Srivasa Thakura." (CC, Madhya 10.76–77)

The news seemed to bring her, Advaita, Srivasa and Haridasa back to life, and the devotees, gathering in Navadvipa, received Shachi's permission and set out for Nilachala (10.78–88). Paramananda Puri, who had come from the south, was then staying in her house: Shachi fed him with reverence, and on hearing the news he hurried to the Lord ahead of the others (10.91–93). From then on it became the custom: every year the devotees of Bengal went to Puri after asking her permission (CC, Antya 12.14), and Advaita, before setting out, would respectfully ask leave of mother Shachi (CB, Antya 8.39).

Once, as He sent the devotees home after the Ratha-yatra, the Lord said to Srivasa:

"'Give My mother this maha-prasada and cloth. Bow to her and ask her to forgive My transgression. Abandoning service to her, I went away and took sannyasa. In doing so I deviated from dharma, and this may ruin My religious life. I am immeasurably indebted to her for her love. My dharma is to serve her. In leaving her I committed an act of madness. But a mother never takes offence at her son, however foolish his deed. So I hope that My mother is not angry with Me.'" (CC, Madhya 15.47–50)

"'Now, at her command, I live in Jagannatha Puri. But from time to time I come to see her. Every day I come to see her feet. She feels My presence but cannot fully believe it.'" (CC, Madhya 15.52–53)

And through Srivasa the Lord reminded her of one day. On Vijaya-dashami she had prepared a great feast — choice rice, shak, a curry of banana flowers, fried patola with nim leaves, ginger with lime, yoghurt, milk and sweets — and offered it to the Shalagrama:

"Then, taking the tray of this prasada on her lap, she burst into tears, thinking: 'My beloved son Nimai loves all these dishes so much. But Nimai is not here. Who will eat all this?' Thinking of Me with such great love, she shed bitter tears. At once I came and ate all these dishes. Seeing the empty tray, she was astonished and wiped away her tears." (CC, Madhya 15.56–58)

"Who has eaten it? Could it be Bala-Gopala Himself? Or was I only imagining it?" she wondered, and finding the pots in the kitchen full, she called Ishana to clean up and prepared a new offering for Gopala; and the Lord, summoned by her love, again ate it all. "Ask her about it," He told Srivasa, "and confirm that she did not imagine anything" (15.59–66).

Srivasa and his brothers, having moved to Kumarahatta, went every year both to the Lord in Nilachala and to Shachi in Mayapur, and then stayed for several days in their house in Navadvipa. "In Bengal I have two merciful refuges — My mother and the Ganga," the Lord would say (CC, Madhya 16.90), and Gadadhara Pandita, not wishing to let Him go alone, said, "I am going not for Your sake, but to see mother Shachi" (16.135).

Five Years Later

Five years after His sannyasa, in 1514, the Lord Himself came to Bengal — to see His mother and the Ganga. For seven days He stayed in Kulia, in the house of Madhava Dasa (CC, Madhya 16.208–209), Vamshivadana's father, and there bestowed His mercy on Devananda Pandita; then He visited Ramakeli and came to Shantipur, to Advaita's house. Having received the Lord of His life in His own home, Advaita was beside Himself with happiness, and when He had calmed a little, He sent people to Navadvipa with a palanquin for mother Shachi (CB, Antya 4.209–212).[23]

Vrindavana Dasa describes the state in which the messengers found her. Through five years of separation Yashoda had come to light in her ever more fully:

"Sometimes mother Shachi would cry out: 'Rama! Krishna! Go quickly and milk the cows. I am going to sell milk.' Sometimes mother Shachi ran about with a stick in her hand, saying: 'Catch Him! Catch Him! Where is that butter thief? You won't escape! Today I shall tie You up.' Saying this, she ran about in bliss." (CB, Antya 4.218–220)

She asked everyone about Mathura — what Krishna and Balarama were doing there, what had become of Kamsa — scolded "the thief Akrura" who had stolen her sons, called on someone to come and bathe in the Yamuna; she wept so that stones cracked, laughed for six hours at a time seeing Krishna in meditation, lay for three hours without a sign of life (4.213–227). And Vrindavana Dasa explains:

"Mother Shachi's ecstatic love cannot be compared with anything. She alone displayed such boundless love. Gaurachandra endowed mother Shachi with the same potency of loving service to Krishna that He Himself possessed." (CB, Antya 4.228–229)

And whenever she came to outer consciousness, it was only to serve Vishnu (4.232).

The news, "Gaurasundara is in Shantipur," filled her with indescribable happiness. Gangadasa Pandita set out with her at once, and Murari Gupta and other devotees joined them.[24] As soon as the Lord saw His mother, He fell prostrate before her, walked around her again and again and, weeping with happiness, prayed to her:

"'You are the Mother of the universe and the embodiment of loving service to God. Your form is wholly spiritual and transcendent to the gunas of material nature. As soon as you cast a merciful glance on living beings, attraction to Krishna awakens in them. You are the embodiment of loving service to Vishnu. You are the divine power that gives rise to everything. You are the Ganga, Devaki, Yashoda, Devahuti, Prishni, Anasuya, Kaushalya and Aditi. All that you see comes from you. You are the keeper of all, and all at last finds rest in you. Who can tell of your greatness? You dwell in the heart of everyone.'" (CB, Antya 4.242–247)

"The Lord said: 'The devotion to Krishna that I possess has come to Me only by your mercy. Millions of servants of your servants are dearer to Me than My own life. Even one who remembers you but once will never again fall into the cycle of birth and death. The Ganga and tulasi purify all they touch. But even they are purified by your touch. I am unable to repay you for the love you showed in caring for Me.'" (CB, Antya 4.253–257)

Shachi, seeing her son's face, stood still in ecstasy. She knew that her son was Narayana Himself and could say whatever He wished, and on coming to herself she answered:

"After a few moments mother Shachi said: 'Is anyone able to understand Your words? Conditioned souls are like lifeless bodies tossed from side to side by the waves of the ocean. All living beings are in the ocean of material existence, wholly in the power of Your illusory energy. My dear son, I can only say that You alone know what the true good of each one is. You may offer prayers, make obeisances and reverently walk around, for I know that You always act as You please.'" (CB, Antya 4.261–265)

The devotees cried out, "Jaya! Jaya!" The mother's happiness made Nityananda mad with ecstasy, and Advaita bowed to her without end, reciting the prayers with which Devaki is glorified (4.266–272).

Advaita asked the Lord to allow Shachi to cook. She cooked with great joy, thinking, "Gaurachandra is Narayana Himself." Knowing that her son loved shak, she prepared twenty kinds of it, and every dish in ten or twenty variations, and laid out the rice and vegetables in rows, adorning them with tulasi blossoms. Entering, the Lord prostrated Himself before this meal: "The mere sight of these dishes frees one from the bonds of material life… I think Krishna Himself with His companions has tasted this feast." He ate, praising each kind of shak, while His mother watched, "wishing to give full satisfaction to her eyes" (CB, Antya 4.276–299); afterwards the devotees, playfully quarrelling, shared out the remnants of His meal (4.305–313). During that same visit Advaita held a festival on the day of worship (aradhana) of His guru Madhavendra Puri, and again "Ai" volunteered to cook, while the wives of the Vaishnavas helped her; the Lord and all the devotees partook of her cooking (CB, Antya 4.441–447, 506). Murari Gupta says that the Lord, "the crest-jewel of those devoted to their mothers", had her

brought from Navadvipa, dispelled her grief and ate the food she had cooked (“Kadacha” 3.18.19–20). He also tells how the Lord, coming from Kulia to Navadvipa, fell at His mother's feet, and she hastily embraced Him and, having fed Him food of the four kinds, “the loving mother was filled with joy” (4.14.4–5), and how Gaura and Nitai, having spent several days with Advaita, “obedient to Their mother's will”, gladdened her with sweet words and left (4.15.6–12).[25]

Krishnadasa Kaviraja speaks of this visit briefly: in Shantipur the Lord met His mother and consoled her, freeing her from all sorrow, and then, returning from Ramakeli, stayed with Advaita for ten days (CC, Madhya 16.210–212).[26] Seeing her son after a long separation, Shachi utterly forgot herself and for many days cooked for Him. And at the farewell the Lord

“humbly fell at His mother's feet and received her permission to set out on the path to Vraja-dhama.” (CC, Madhya 16.249)

Mother Shachi was escorted back to Navadvipa, and the Lord returned to Nilachala (16.250).

Nityananda with Shachi

The Lord sent Nityananda to preach in Bengal, and He, going from village to village, one day felt a desire to see mother Shachi (CB, Antya 5.421). Coming to Navadvipa, He went first of all to her house and bowed at her feet:

“Mother Shachi said: ‘My dear son. Surely You are the Supersoul of all creation, for I have been able to see You as soon as I wished it. Knowing my desire, You appeared here at once. So who in this world can understand You? My dear son, stay in Navadvipa for a little while, so that I may see You every ten, fifteen or thirty days.’” (CB, Antya 5.499–501)

“O mother of all that exists, I have come here to see you,” answered Nityananda, “and with your permission I shall stay in Navadvipa” (5.504–505). Murari Gupta tells of this meeting thus: “Mother, I have come, and I am happy!” said Nityananda, and she, placing her hands on His head, begged, “Stay in my house, so that I may always see You.” He replied with a smile:

“‘Mother, listen, I will tell you the truth: I and My younger brother always live beside you, always close to you. The food you cook is filled with the nectar of Sri Krishna's lips — it is out of longing for it, Mother, that I always stay near you.’” (“Kadacha” 4.23.4–5)

And when she served the meal, she saw that it was Rama and Krishna who were eating it, and was plunged in an ocean of joy (4.23.6–8).

After His marriage Nityananda brought His wives, Vasudha and Jahnava, to her; Shachi welcomed them with great joy, would not let them out of her embrace and tenderly caressed them both. At her wish Nityananda then lived nearby for some time before settling in Khardaha.[27] And when separation from Gaura became unbearable, He would ask Shachi's permission and go back to Nilachala (CB, Antya 7.10–11).

Damodara Pandita and Jagadananda

The most impartial of His companions, Damodara Pandita, the Lord sent to live with His mother:

“Apart from you I see no one who could look after her and protect her. You have surrounded even Me with your care.” (CC, Antya 3.22)

“Go to My mother's house and take shelter at her holy feet. In your presence no one will dare to behave as he pleases.” (CC, Antya 3.25)

Damodara was told to bow to her again and again on her son's behalf, to tell her how well He was, and to remind her of one secret:

“Tell her: ‘O My dear mother! Again and again I come to your house and eat all the sweets and vegetable dishes that you offer Me…’” (CC, Antya 3.30)

On the last Magha-sankranti, the Lord went on, she had prepared various dishes, cakes, sweet rice and condensed milk, offered them to Krishna and sat down to meditate. Suddenly He came and hastily ate it all, and her eyes filled with tears of joy; but when she had wiped them she saw the empty tray and decided that she had dreamt it. Then, in the confusion of separation, she thought that she had not made the offering at all, went to the kitchen, found the pots full, cleaned the place and offered again (3.32–37).

“Thus again and again I ate all the offerings you made Me, attracted by your pure love. I live in Jagannatha Puri only in obedience to your instruction. Yet the power of your pure love draws Me so irresistibly that I am unable to resist.” (CC, Antya 3.38–39)

Damodara brought her Jagannatha's prasada — for her and for the devotees of Navadvipa — and stayed to live at her feet (3.40–42).

Once, when Damodara had visited Shachi and returned to Nilachala, the Lord called him aside and asked, “You have been staying with My mother. Tell Me the truth: is she devoted to Lord Vishnu?” The stern Damodara answered in anger:

“‘O Gosvami, what are You saying? You ask whether Your mother has devotion to God? Your devotion to Lord Vishnu has come to You by the mercy of Your mother. All that You have has come through her. Know that all the devotion You have has come to You by her mercy. On mother Shachi's body one can always see such signs of divine love for Vishnu as weeping, trembling, perspiration, fainting, hair standing on end and loud cries. She constantly chants the holy name of Krishna. O Gosvami, You ask about mother Shachi's devotion? Is it not mother Shachi who is addressed as Vishnu-bhakti, loving devotion to Vishnu?’” (CB, Antya 9.95–100)

The Lord's happiness knew no bounds. He embraced Damodara:

“‘O Damodara, today you have bought Me, fully confirming the feeling of My heart. All the devotion to Vishnu that I possess has come to Me by the mercy of My mother. Of this there is no doubt. By her will I live in this world. Therefore I can never repay her for it. O Damodara, please hear Me. I am wholly conquered by her love. I always see her.’” (CB, Antya 9.105–108)

He asked, says Vrindavana Dasa, only to instruct the world (9.110). Murari Gupta gives the same conversation: “It is only by her grace that there is in You that devotion,” Damodara answered angrily, and the Lord said, “It is only by her command that I live in this Kshetra — and yet her love draws Me back to her again and again” (“Kadacha” 4.20.1–4).

Every year the Lord sent Jagadananda to His mother as well. He bowed at her feet on the Lord's behalf, gave her cloth and Jagannatha's prasada, conveyed the Lord's humble prayers, and she listened day and night to his tales of her son. “Sometimes,” Jagadananda told her, “Chaitanya comes to you and eats, and afterwards says, ‘Today Mother has fed Me to the full,’” and Shachi confessed:

“Shachimata said: ‘How I wish that Nimai would eat all these dishes that I cook from the finest vegetables. Sometimes it seems to me that Nimai has eaten all the food on the tray, but afterwards I take it for a dream.’” (CC, Antya 12.93–94)

One biography adds that Jagadananda, naming the exact days, confirmed to her that her son had come in reality, and she believed that it was no dream.[28] Next to her house lived the confectioner Parameshvara,

who also went to Puri with the pilgrims from Bengal (12.54).

Krishnadasa Kaviraja calls the Lord “the crown of all who are devoted to their mother” and gives His words, which Jagadananda carried to Nadia every year:

“‘Go to Nadia and convey My obeisances to My mother. On My behalf touch her lotus feet. Tell her: “Remember, every day I come and bow at your feet. Whenever you wish to feed Me, I surely come and eat all that you offer. I abandoned service to you and took sannyasa. I became a madman and neglected My duty. Do not hold this offence against Me. I am in your power — for I am your son. I live in Nilachala at your command and, as long as I live, I cannot leave this place.”’” (CC, Antya 19.6–11)

The prasada-cloth from the festival of Jagannatha's cowherd pastimes the Lord, on the advice of Paramananda Puri, sent to His mother, and the best prasada He collected separately for her and the devotees (19.12–13):

“Mahaprabhu is the crown of all who are devoted to their mother. Even after taking sannyasa, He always served her.” (CC, Antya 19.14)

After staying a month in Nadia, Jagadananda returned to Puri with her permission (19.15–16). In sending His mother Jagannatha's prasada, the sannyasi Lord showed not worldly attachment but transcendental love for His eternal companions — and His mother is the first of them. Nor did He ever leave her:

“The Lord is always attracted by divine love, for such is His nature. Therefore Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu always manifested Himself in four places: in mother Shachi's home temple, in the place where Nityananda Prabhu dances, in the kirtana of Srivasa Thakura and in the house of Raghava Pandita.” (CC, Antya 2.34–35)

Departure and Remembrance

When Shachi Devi hid herself from the eyes of this world the original sources do not say; the days of her appearance and departure are not in the Vaishnava calendar either. Ishana and Vamshivadana — the servants and protectors of Shachi and Vishnupriya — were with her to the end; every morning Vishnupriya went with her to bathe in the Ganga and ate only the remnants of her food; and their affairs, according to one biography, were also managed by Gadadhara Dasa, who, when they were gone, moved to Katva. All that is known is that after the departure of Mahaprabhu and Shachi Vamshivadana served Vishnupriya and the aged Ishana, and that Jahnava, coming to the Lord's house in Navadvipa after the festival at Kheturi, no longer found Shachi there and grieved that she had missed her. To Srinivasa Acharya, who came to Navadvipa to the Lord's family, mother Shachi showed mercy, “appearing as if in a dream” (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 4.55).[29]

Her memory is kept by songs. Vasudeva Ghosha sings of the Boy who circles about Shachi's courtyard, hides and teases His mother, and when she calls, “Vishvambhara, where are You?” runs to her and catches the hem of her sari. And Narottama Dasa sums it up: the son of the king of Vraja has become the son of Shachi, and Balarama has become Nitai. When the Lord's birthplace was rediscovered at the end of the nineteenth century, Jagannatha Dasa Babaji proposed that the Deities of Jagannatha and Shachi be worshipped there in one temple, and Mahaprabhu with Lakshmipriya and Vishnupriya in another.

Queen of Vraja

Who, then, was this brahmana woman of Navadvipa, a widow who lost eight daughters and her husband and let two sons go into sannyasa? The original sources answer with one voice: the Mother of the universe, Yashoda, service to Vishnu embodied. In her arms wept He whom time and death fear; her cooking was eaten by Him, coming secretly from Nilachala, for whose sake sages fast; her permission

was asked, on leaving, by Him who depends on no one. Only His eternal companion can treat the Lord as a son, and the whole of Shachi's life — from the lullaby to the twelve-day fast — is vatsalya, pure motherly love, in which the Lord's majesty is not forgotten but dissolved. The Lord Himself told her, “Nothing will ever separate you and Me”; and He still appears in her house, for where He is loved so, He cannot but be.

1. Some biographies call Chandrashekhara only the husband of the Lord's mother's sister (citing “some sources”); others, following the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana”, also give the sister's name — Sarvajaya.

2. According to one biography, Devaki and Vasudeva also entered into Shachi and Jagannatha. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (38) names Aditi, Kaushalya and Prishni, and of Devaki and Vasudeva says only: “Some say” (39). In Murari Gupta the gods, praising Shachi, say to her: “You are Devaki, Rohini and Yashoda” (“Kadacha” 1.5.9).

3. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” names a different giver of the name: “Touching the baby's head with fresh grass and rice, she [Sita Thakurani] blessed Him with the words: ‘May the life of both brothers be long!’ And to protect Him from witches and evil spirits, she named Him Nimai” (CC, Adi 13.117). The biographies follow now one, now the other of these sources: according to some, the name was given by Shachi and the other women or by the neighbours; according to others, by Sita.

4. According to one biography, Shachi and Jagannatha then saw the divine form of Nimai asleep on the snake, like Narayana on Shesha, and became convinced of His divinity. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 4.67–75) speaks only of the parents' fear.

5. One biography, retelling these lines of Lochana Dasa, adds that Shachi, looking into her son's mouth, saw the universe there; this is found neither in the text of the “Chaitanya-mangala” nor in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's summary (at this place: “fearing misfortune to come, she fell into anxiety”).

6. According to one biography, Shachi sent her son to take Vishvarupa His lunch. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, it was to call His brother home for the meal (Adi 7.34–40; cf. Madhya 2.22, 22.93).

7. Shachi is not named in the Lord's reply; one biography writes that He called Jagannatha and Shachi His father and mother.

8. According to one account, both parents interrupted His studies and themselves sent their son back to school after hearing His words in the spirit of Dattatreya; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, the ban was imposed by the father against Shachi's objection, and he gave way to her request and the neighbours' persuasion (Adi 7.128, 193–197). In Lochana Dasa, on the contrary, Shachi says to her husband: “Let my son be a dunce — as long as He lives a hundred years” (CM, Adi-khanda, part 6, v. 494).

9. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 14.177–178), the Lord was told of Lakshmi's death by the relatives; according to Lochana Dasa and Murari Gupta, Shachi herself told Him everything (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, v. 148; “Kadacha” 1.12.11). One biography writes that He was told of Lakshmi's death by the neighbours.

10. Gaudiya Vaishnavas, following Vrindavana Dasa, see in Lakshmipriya Lakshmi herself; the story of the apsara is the words with which the Lord consoled His mother while concealing Himself. Murari Gupta at once adds in the Lord's words: “Or else it was the Mistress of the world herself, in the form of Lakshmi, who went to the lotus feet of her Lord” (“Kadacha” 1.12.17), and concludes: “Thus did Hari, playing the part of a man, conceal His manifest glory” (1.12.18).

11. One biography, retelling the “Chaitanya-mangala”, calls the matchmaker “Dvija Kashishvara”; in the “Chaitanya-mangala” itself, as in Murari Gupta and the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, he is the brahmana Kashinatha.

12. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, the Lord granted prema to His mother only after Advaita had forgiven her (Madhya 22.11, 52; see below, the section “Shachi and Advaita”); in Lochana Dasa and Murari Gupta the gift of prema comes soon after Gaya. Both accounts agree in the main: prema comes to Shachi “by the mercy of the Vaishnavas”. One biography, retelling the “Chaitanya-mangala”, writes that the Lord then “praised His mother's good fortune”; in Lochana Dasa it is the author himself who glorifies the good fortune of the Lord's students, while to His mother the Lord gives prema at her request.

13. One biography retells this dream thus: Shachi saw that Gaura and Nitai were Kanai and Balai of Vraja Themselves. In the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” in the dream They quarrel with the Deities of Krishna and Balarama, and it is in waking, at the meal, that Shachi sees Them in the forms of Krishna and Balarama; the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” says briefly that Shachi saw in Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda the two brothers Krishna and Balarama (Adi 17.17).

14. Nityananda, according to Gaudiya Vaishnava theology, is Balarama Himself, and Vishvarupa too is a manifestation of Sankarshana; therefore Shachi naturally loves Nityananda as her son and recognises Vishvarupa in Him. The Lord's words “This is Vishvarupa…” are found only in the 1983 edition of the “Chaitanya-mangala” (vv. 80+10–80+11).

15. One biography calls her Lakshmipriya; but at that time, after the Lord's return from Gaya, His wife was Vishnupriya. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says “Lakshmi” (Madhya 22.112) — as Vrindavana Dasa here calls Vishnupriya too (cf. Madhya 11.65–68).

16. According to one biography, Srivasa asked that Shachi might see His divine form, and when the offence had been lifted, the Lord showed her that form. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, Srivasa asked prema for her, and the Lord, pleased with His mother, declared that she had attained devotion to Vishnu (Madhya 22.24, 52); so also another biography.

17. This account is found only in the 1983 edition of the “Chaitanya-mangala”; it is absent from the editions of 1903 and 1922.

18. One biography writes that it was Shachi who had this dream of the sannyasa mantra; according to the “Chaitanya-mangala”, the dream was seen by the Lord Himself, who told it to those close to Him.

19. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, Nityananda sent Chandrashekhara first to Advaita and then to Navadvipa for mother Shachi and the devotees (Madhya 3.20–22, 137). According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, it was Nityananda Himself who went for them, at the Lord's command (Antya 1.127–176); so too in Lochana Dasa (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 56–64) and Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 3.4.7–10). The meeting of mother and son in Shantipur after the sannyasa is not itself described in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”. The biographies name different companions of Shachi on this journey: Chandrashekhara, Murari Gupta, “one of those who were there”.

20. These lines are found only in the 1983 edition of the “Chaitanya-mangala”; the same edition says that in Shantipur it was Shachi who cooked (v. 88+1; the 1903 edition gives this line only in a footnote).

21. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, it was Shachi herself who decided that He should live in Puri (Madhya 3.181–185); so too in its other passages (Madhya 15.52; Antya 3.39, 19.11) and in Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 4.20.4): the Lord lives in Nilachala “at her command”. In Lochana Dasa the Lord in Shantipur Himself gives the devotees a vow: “truly I shall dwell in Nilachala” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 19, vv. 49–54). The biographies write that He settled in Puri “at the wish”, “at the request” or “at the command” of His mother.

22. So in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Madhya 3.209–210). One biography writes that Damodara Pandita went with the Lord at the instruction of Shachi herself.

23. According to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”, Advaita then “did not delay to invite Shachidevi” (Madhya 1.233); one biography also writes that it was Advaita who sent for Shachi and that the news brought her almost lifeless body back to life.

24. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4.237–238) names Gangadasa and Murari; one biography, naming Gangadasa, places this journey at the Lord's coming to Shantipur after His sannyasa.

25. Murari Gupta places this meeting with His mother (the Lord came to her in Navadvipa from Kulia) and the festival in honour of Madhavendra Puri at the Lord's return to Bengal after His journey to Vrindavana; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” tells of the festival of Madhavendra Puri during this visit (Antya 4.441–508).

26. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”, His mother came to her son in Shantipur when He was returning from Ramakeli (Antya 4); according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Madhya 16.210–212), the Lord saw her both before Ramakeli and after it; so too one biography. How many days the Lord then stayed in Shantipur the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” gives differently: a week, during which Shachi cooked for seven days (Madhya 1.232–234), or ten days (Madhya 16.212).

27. According to one biography, at Shachi's request Nityananda lived for some time in Navadvipa after His wedding, then moved to Saptagrama to Uddharana Datta and finally to Khardaha; according to another, at her word He went straight to Advaita's house in Shantipur and stayed there until Uddharana Datta invited Him to Saptagrama.

28. One biography writes that after the chaturmasya Vasudeva Datta, Murari Gupta and Jagadananda came to Shachi with news of the Lord, and she gladly kept them with her and long would not let them go; according to the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Antya 12.98), it was Murari Gupta and Vasudeva Datta who would not let Jagadananda go.

29. One biography, citing the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.20–24), writes that Vamshivadana, on meeting Srinivasa, went to tell Vishnupriya and Shachimata of his arrival; in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” itself only Vishnupriya is named (4.24). The same biography, like another, says that after the departure of Mahaprabhu and Shachi Vamshivadana served Vishnupriya and Ishana: by then Shachi had already withdrawn from the eyes of this world.